Operation Black Thunderstorm (26 April 2009)

This operation was undertaken to regain control of Buner and Shangla districts, Lower Dir district and Swat district from the Taliban after the military took control of them since early 2009. Within the first ten days of the operation, the militants were on the run. The army rapidly cleared town after town and made quick progress. The ferocious Swat TTP was defeated in the fire and fury of the army. Air power was also used to destroy their hideouts and underground tunnels in the mountains. More than 1,700 militants were killed, as claimed by the ISPR (*The Nation*, 2009). At least 260 soldiers were killed. Approximately 3 million people, almost as many Afghan refugees who had come to Pakistan during the Soviet–Afghan War, were internally displaced.

The US Joint Chief of Staff Chairman Admiral Mike Mullen acknowledged that Pakistan made an 'awful lot of progresses' in its fight against the Taliban insurgency in Swat (*The Nation*, 2009). The operation was therefore declared to have entered the wrapping up stage on 8 July 2009.

However, the later developments showed that much more needed to be done to annihilate the insurgents in different agencies of FATA, especially in North Waziristan. Apart from small operations, an all-out military campaign seemed necessary to dismantle the command and control structures of the well-entrenched TTP insurgents and their affiliates. Therefore, Operation 'Zarb-e-Azb' was launched in 2014.

Operation 'Zarb-e-Azb' was started on 15 June 2014 with a serious intent to annihilate the TTP and its affiliates, which held large swathes of FATA. US drone campaign was already taking care of Al Qaeda and its foreign associates in the same area. It was the twenty-third mentionable military operation against the insurgents and terrorists in FATA.

The newly elected government of Pakistan made serious efforts to negotiate with TTP to reach an agreement for peace. However, these attempts failed miserably and the insurgents and terrorists continued their activities, rather adopting a more brutal and lethal approach of destruction. Following a terrorist attack on Karachi airport, the government's peace talks with TTP came to an end and Operation 'Zarb-e-Azb' was launched. The government and political forces gave a unanimous go ahead to the military to end the menace of terrorism.

Military went in with full might and fury, employing all the tools at its disposal, like artillery and air force. The COAS General Raheel Sharif